

fridayReview

THE HINDU

World Music Day

Sitarist Purbayan Chatterjee on how merit scores over inherited privilege **p2**

From the master's repertoire

A book of Thanjavur Kalyanaraman's thillanas with notations released **p2**

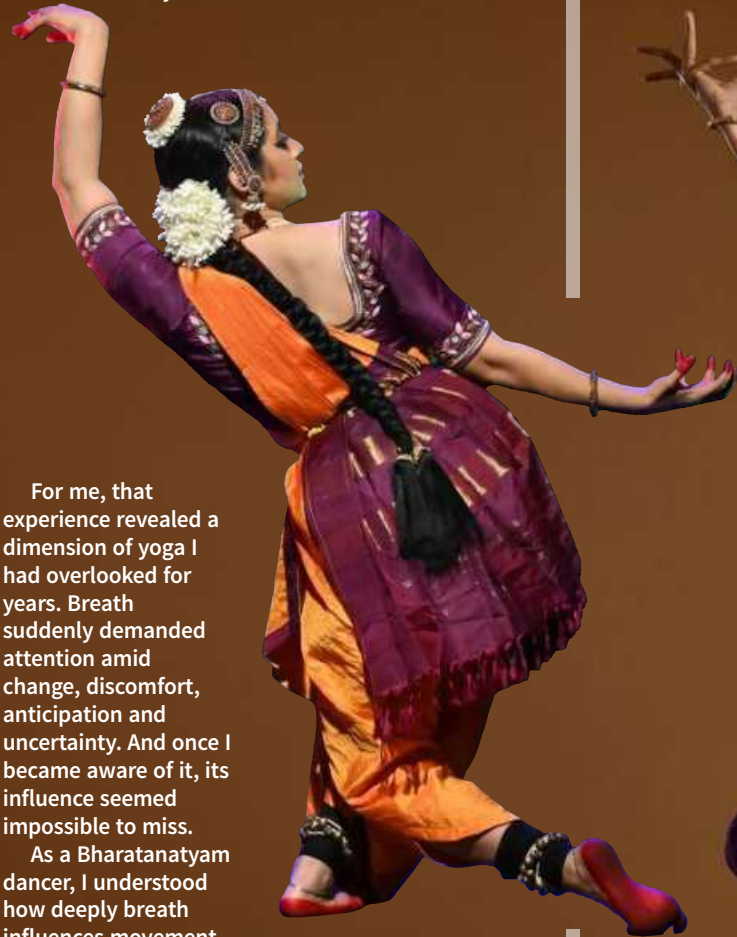


SHARING THE SPOTLIGHT

Uganda's Ghetto Kids to perform with Shakira on football's biggest stage **p4**

Meera Sreenarayanan

Yoga has been a part of my life since childhood. As a young Bharatanatyam dancer, it felt like an extension of my training. Flexibility, balance, mobility and strength were the yardsticks of progress. The body needed to be trained, honed and understood. Then came marriage and motherhood. Every pregnancy is different and deeply personal. This is simply my story. Years of dance training cultivate a sense of agency over the body. This phase offers a humbling reminder that not everything can be directed, corrected or rehearsed. Life takes shape breath by breath.



For me, that experience revealed a dimension of yoga I had overlooked for years. Breath suddenly demanded attention amid change, discomfort, anticipation and uncertainty. And once I became aware of it, its influence seemed impossible to miss.

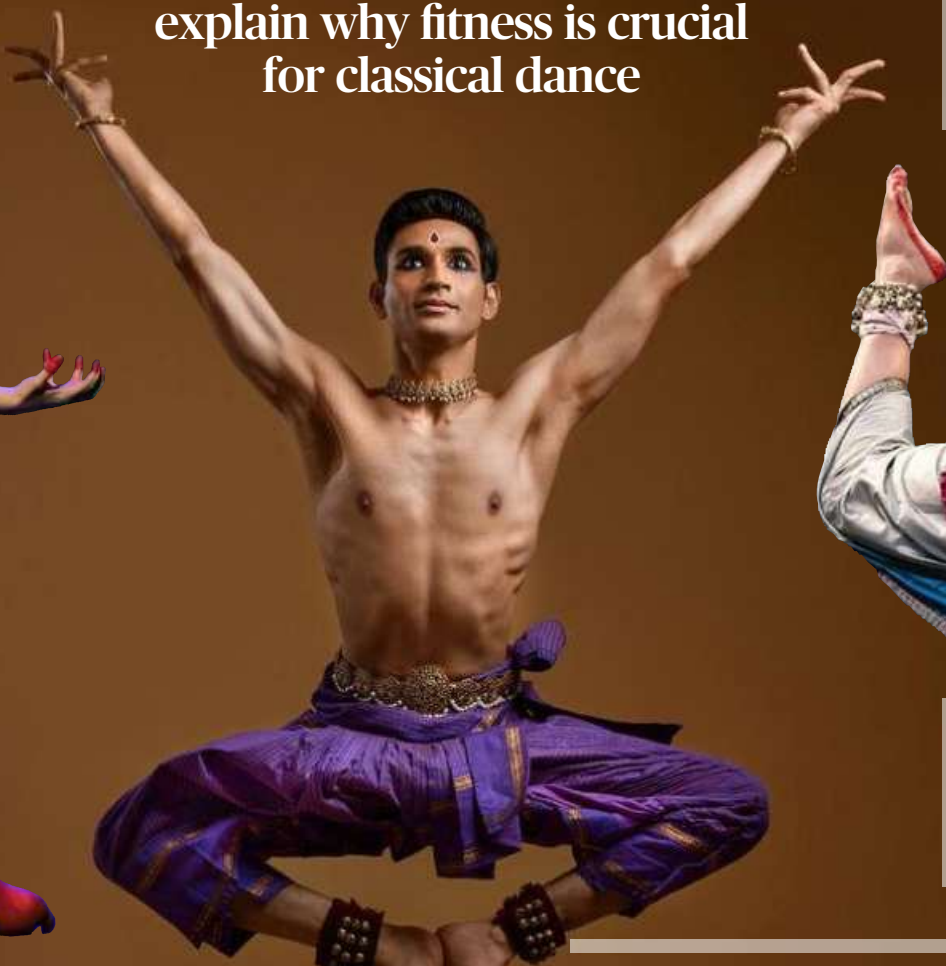
As a Bharatanatyam dancer, I understood how deeply breath influences movement. The quality of a movement often depends on the quality of the breath that precedes it. The same is true of abhinaya. Before an emotion appears in the eyes, face or body, it often announces itself in the breath. Paying attention to that brought a new honesty to expression.

This insight followed me beyond dance. Whenever something felt out of sync, the answer was rarely to push harder. More often, it was to pay closer attention.

In a world where conversations about fitness often centre on doing more, yoga continues to remind me of the value of noticing more. For years, I thought yoga was helping me become a better dancer. It took pregnancy to show me that it was helping me become a more attentive human.

Body in balance

Ahead of International Yoga Day, three young artistes explain why fitness is crucial for classical dance



Avijit Das

When I look back at my training in Kuchipudi, I realise how pranayama, yoga and breathing techniques have shaped me as an artiste. The dance form, with its blend of rhythm, expression and storytelling, is demanding, requiring a dancer to align both body and mind. These have, therefore, remained a constant.

Pranayama has given me the ability to centre myself before stepping into practice or performance. In classical dance, where abhinaya (expression) and nritta (pure dance) must flow seamlessly, controlled breathing helps me maintain focus and

emotional balance. Practices such as 'anulom vilom' and 'kapalabhati' sharpen my energy and steady my mind. This steadiness enables me to sustain long hours of rehearsal and navigate the intensity of performance. It also allows me to channel devotion and emotion more deeply into my dance — an essential aspect of Kuchipudi's storytelling tradition.

In dance, where every movement is anchored in rhythm and emotion, breath becomes the thread that connects the two. I have learnt to coordinate my inhalations and exhalations with the tala (beat), allowing for smoother transitions.

Preetisha Mohapatra

For a 27-year-old Odissi dancer, physical fitness is a significant part in sustaining body aesthetics. While traditional Odissi inherently incorporates yogic movements inspired by ancient temple sculptures, contemporary performance environment demands a rigorous, multi-dimensional approach to conditioning.

Building on the foundational legacy of my grandfather, Guru Kelucharan Mohapatra, who meticulously researched injury prevention to refine iconic postures such as the tribhangi, and my father, Odissi exponent Ratikant Mohapatra, who reworked toe-and-knee alignment following his own experience with a severe ligament injury, I have incorporated specialised weight training into my daily regimen. While dance provides excellent

cardio, strength and endurance, a solo performance requires sustained stamina to command the stage for an hour. Today's challenges, including shifts in lifestyle, environment and dietary quality, necessitate targeted resistance training and strict nutritional discipline. Weight training specifically builds and preserves muscle mass, shielding the skeletal structure from the physical shocks of ageing. This pro-active discipline ensures that the body remains intact, highly resilient and capable of enduring the rigorous physical demands of classical dance well into the future.

Classical dance is a slow, layered journey. While an artiste in the twenties is still evolving, it is in the forties and fifties that the form acquires depth and richness. To sustain this progress, the body must be nurtured from within early on.

The sculptural postures of Odissi — the tribhangi, chauka and related stances — carry an inherent yogic sensibility, offering both alignment and internal balance. My mother, senior dancer-choreographer Sujatha Mohapatra, follows a dedicated yoga regimen, practising Surya Namaskar and attributes her physical stamina and mental focus to it.

Armed with the awareness passed down by my predecessors, my generation has the rare advantage of learning from past injuries. By combining this inherited wisdom with contemporary sports science, we can build the physical resilience required to sustain a long, injury-free artistic journey.

Breath also carries rasa, the emotional flavour of the performance. A forceful exhalation can heighten the drama of a battle scene, while a gentle inhalation can soften the mood in a devotional piece. In this way, breathing transforms my dance from mere physical movement into a living, expressive art.

Kuchipudi calls for agility, strength and grace — whether in executing brisk footwork, sustaining ardhmandalam (half-sitting posture), or holding statuesque poses in dramatic sequences. Through yoga, I have strengthened my core, improved my posture and gained the flexibility that lends fluidity to my movements. It has

also helped prevent injuries, keeping my joints supple and my body aligned. Beyond the physical benefits, yoga has instilled patience and discipline. Holding a pose and breathing through discomfort mirror the endurance required when rehearsing complex Kuchipudi choreography.

Pranayama, yoga and breathing techniques together have given me the strength to endure rigorous training, the resilience to face challenges and the maturity to express myself on stage. I feel aligned both physically and spiritually, and that sense of union allows me to convey the true essence of the art form.

Bharatanatyam guru, composer and choreographer Madurai R. Muralidharan presents 'Saptatāla Lahari', a three-day Bharatanatyam festival that celebrates the grandeur of the Sapta Sulādi tala system.

To be held from June 19 at Krishna Gana Sabha, it will showcase seven margams choreographed and performed in seven distinct talas.

Bharatanatyam has always flourished through a balance of tradition, scholarship, creativity and innovation. While rhythm (tala) forms one of the fundamental pillars of Indian classical dance, extensive exploration of the Sulādi Sapta tala system within the traditional margam structure has remained relatively rare. Recognising this vast and untapped rhythmic landscape, Muralidharan embarked on a journey to integrate the 35 Sulādi Sapta talas into the Bharatanatyam

When tala takes centre stage

R. Muralidharan presents seven margams in seven talas at a three-day festival in Chennai.

repertoire.

"I have always been intrigued by the way rhythm navigates through emotions in dance. It made explore further and come up with exclusive pieces that revolve around talas. It has been an exciting process - blending lyric, movement and mood. The first time I attempted, it drove me to go deeper. Research revealed how the dance form offers immense possibilities in the area of rhythm. My students have been enjoying performing these compositions. My aim is to present margams in all



35 talas." says Murlidharan. Prior to Saptatāla Lahari, he had staged choreographic productions titled 'Atula Shanmarga Yagnam', 'Chaturvidam', 'Sumedha' and 'Dhimahi'. He had presented 19 margams in 19 different talas drawn from the Sapta Sulādi tala system.

With the presentation of seven additional margams during this festival, the total will be 26 margams in 26 distinct talas.

The festival will feature Sankeerna Jathi Eka Talam - 9 aksharas; Misra Jathi Triputa Talam - 11 aksharas; Chathusra Jathi Matya Talam - 10 aksharas; Chathusra Jathi Jhampa Talam - 7 aksharas; Chathusra Jathi Triputa Talam - 8 aksharas; Thisra Jathi Rupaka Talam - 5 aksharas and Sankeerna Jathi

Kavya Muralidharan will perform on the opening day of the festival.

Jhampa Talam - 12 aksharas Each margam will consist of the traditional sequence of the Bharatanatyam repertoire: Pushpanjali, Alarippu, Kavithuvam, Jathiswaram, Varnam, Padam and Tillana.

Saptatāla Lahari also incorporates several uncommon ragas chosen to complement the rhythmic character of each tala. The festival features performances by dancers from around the country and abroad.

Following is the list of performances: Today, 5.30 p.m.: K. Sree Mourya; 7.15 p.m.: Kavya Muralidharan. June 20, 5 p.m.: Priyanka Sai Sankar and Padmavati Sai Sankar; 7.15 p.m.: Aishwarya Valli Kakulapati. June 21, 10.30 a.m.: Sriranjani Swaminathan, Lakshmi Ananthanarayan, Rekha Garg and Amritha Narayan; 5 p.m.: Shrivya Suresh and 7.15 p.m.: Harini N.S.

Each day several eminent artistes will be present as chief guests.

CULTUREBRIEFS



Endowment concerts

The Music Academy has organised the following endowment concerts at Kasturi Srinivasan Hall. Time: 6 p.m.: Details: June 22: Bhadrachala Ramadas compositions to be rendered by Madhumitha Doraiswamy . The concert is organised under the endowment, instituted by B. Dayananda Rao, in memory of his wife B. Subhadra. June 23: Dikshitar Day concert will be

presented by R. Suryaprakash. The programme is held under the endowment of P. Obul Reddy and P. Gnanamba. June 24: Salem Gayathri Venkatesan will perform for Papanasam Sivan Day. The concert is organised under the endowment of M/s Arun Excello Urban Infrastructure Private Limited. June 25: Mysore Vasudevachar Day will feature Sweta Balasubramanian's concert. The thematic concert is held under the endowment, instituted by Gomathi Visvanathan through Kala Mandir Trust.

Silver jubilee celebrations

Naadhabrahmam United Gyan Academi celebrates International Music and Yoga Day and its 25th anniversary on June 21, 6.05 p.m., at Chellammal Vidyalaya Senior Secondary School, Hindu Colony, Nanganallur. On the occasion, the 'Naadha Vinodhini' title will be presented to musician and researcher S. Kamnony from Kerala. R. Seshasayee, chairman, Asian Paints, will preside over and present the title. The evening will also feature Udayalur Kalyanaraman's 'Guru Smaranam'.

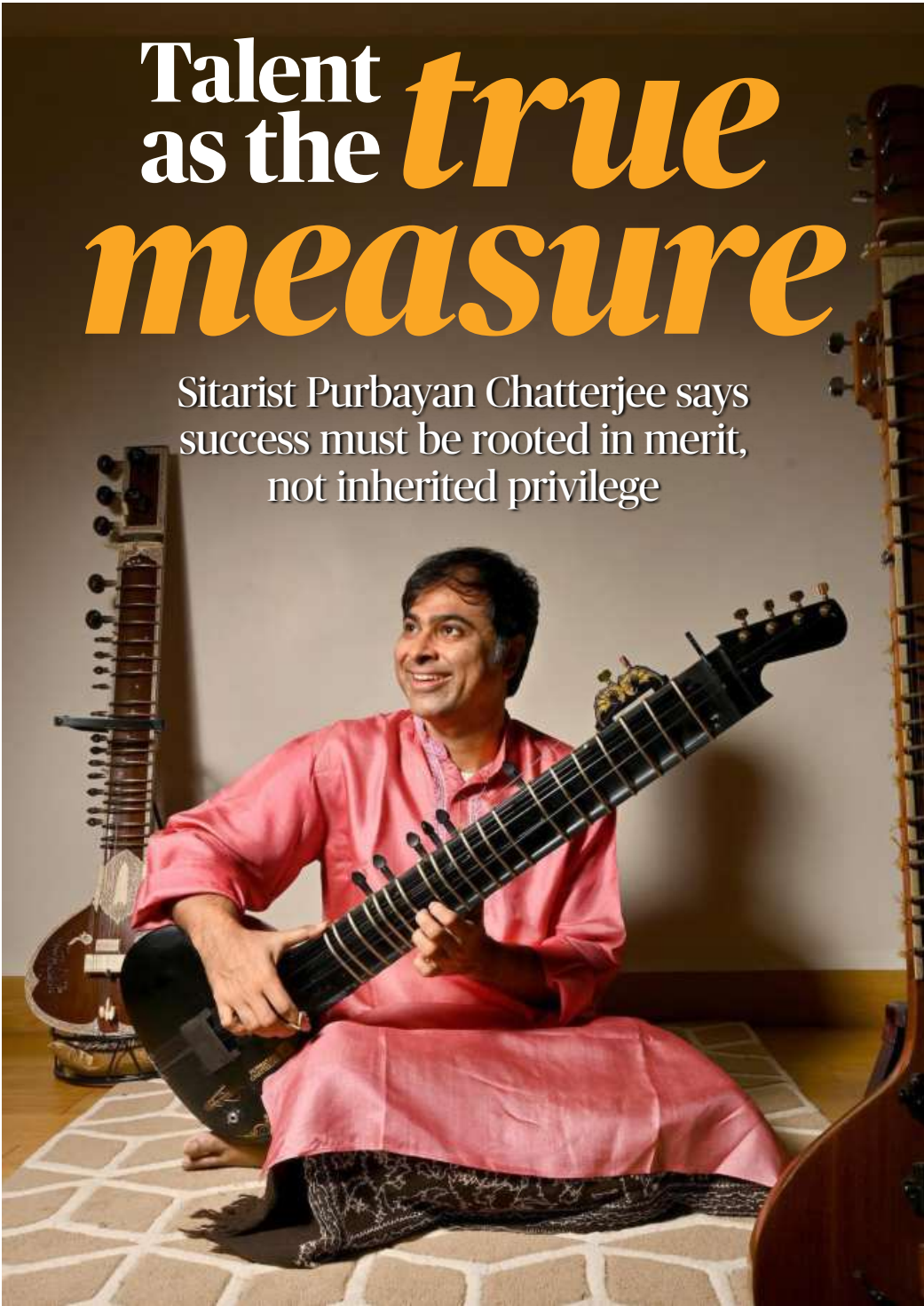
WORLD MUSIC DAY

Bindu Gopal Rao

Pushing boundaries has almost become the norm for classical musicians today. Many are eager to explore new terrains through their sustained engagement with raga, tala and laya. No longer confined to rehearsals, performances and teaching, they are constantly seeking like-minded artistes for collaboration, creating tracks that foreground their creativity and taking on unconventional projects that challenge their artistic limits. Purbayan Chatterjee fits this description perfectly. He has worked with the likes of Ustad Zakir Hussain, Pat Metheny, Béla Fleck and Jordan Rudess, among others, and is busy carving his own niche through classical performances and genre-defying presentations.

Purbayan was brought up in a traditional environment where he was taught to uphold the sanctity and grammar of classical music. But as he began interacting with musicians from different cultures and genres, he slowly realised that music, at its core, is a heartfelt response in the moment to another artistic idea. “Over time, many of the walls and limitations that existed in my mind quietly dissolved. That allowed me to blend my understanding of raga-based music with nuances borrowed from other musical styles in a seamless and honest way. As for electrified sounds, I still deeply love the tone of my acoustic sitar. But sometimes, certain emotions expect you to unlock an entirely different form of expression. I try to use those textures selectively, only when the music genuinely calls for it,” he says.

An exponent of the Senia Maihar gharana, Purbayan understands the need to navigate the tension between preserving a centuries-old tradition and reshaping it for



Gen-Next audiences. “Cultural inheritance, much like material inheritance, survives only when it is preserved and allowed to evolve with the times,” he says. Whatever he learnt from his father, Pt. Partha Pratim Chatterjee, as well as from the legacies of Ustad Ali Akbar Khan and Pt. Ajoy Chakraborty, was never meant to become a museum

piece. “Tradition gives you the grammar, but your experience gives you the vocabulary. My responsibility now is to pass that knowledge on to my students in a way that allows them to interpret it according to the perspective of their generation,” he adds.

For someone who has who has been vocal about the ‘nepotism debate’, Purbayan

believes that parental identity eventually becomes a small part of who you are. “As I began travelling and performing at a young age, I became rebellious towards the idea that destiny should be predetermined at birth. I was inspired by stories of Pt. Nikhil Banerjee, who carved his own path entirely on merit. After moving to Mumbai 14 years

ago, a city that has given me so much, I realised that many traditional structures within our industry still revolved around access, familiarity and inherited privilege.” For Purbayan, success should emerge from meritocracy, not hereditary privilege or favouritism. That realisation became one of the driving forces behind initiatives such as Purbayan Arts and Artists Music Foundation (PAAMF), where he consciously creates platforms and opportunities for young musicians from all backgrounds who just need belief, mentorship and visibility.

Purbayan’s new album *Feathered Creatures*, which released recently, was an organic outcome of his friendship with Grammy-winning guitarist Mark Lettieri of Snarky Puppy. The album emerged from his search for a collaborator who was not only an exceptional musician but also fluent in

modern production, groove-based music, electronics and sonic architecture. “Mark came into the project with immense curiosity and zero ego, and together we almost approached the album like explorers setting out to discover a new musical galaxy. The challenge for me was learning how to retain the emotional and spiritual depth of the raga while placing it inside futuristic soundscapes, synth textures, odd grooves and highly produced environments. It pushed me out of comfort zones I didn’t even know I had, and that is always a beautiful thing for an artiste,” he says.

Additionally, actor Farhan Akhtar is working closely with PAAMF for his Hollywood debut in the Beatles biopic, in which he will portray sitar maestro Pt. Ravi Shankar. “I was initially approached by Anurag Rao, a friend who works closely with Farhan.

Later, Farhan himself got in touch. I was impressed by his willingness to learn the instrument purely for artistic authenticity.”

In projects such as ‘Unbounded’ (Abaad), Purbayan has seamlessly blended Indian classical with jazz. Given the complexity of chromatic jazz improvisation, the biggest lesson he learnt from masters such as Béla Fleck and Antonio Sánchez is that what Indian musicians bring to the table is an incredibly rich and emotionally layered melodic language. “When you place that against sophisticated Western harmonic thinking, the real art lies in making aesthetically justified choices. Not every possibility needs to be explored simply because it exists. The balance between raga and harmony requires restraint, sensitivity and taste. Often, it takes a lifetime of listening, absorbing and unlearning before one can instinctively make those choices in a way that feels organic rather than intellectual,” he says.

Purbayan believes the modern-day guru must not only teach but also prepare students to survive and thrive in a rapidly changing world. Young musicians need guidance to build sustainable careers, diversify their skills, understand technology, navigate legal and financial realities and apply their musical knowledge across multiple avenues. “At the same time, I strongly feel that both genders need to remain vigilant about predatory behaviour and unhealthy power dynamics. While humility, surrender and respect remain central values within the guru-sishya parampara, dignity and self-respect must never be compromised. Sometimes it takes courage to stand your ground, and although that may create temporary obstacles, in the long run, integrity always pays off,” says Purbayan.



Purbayan Chatterjee has collaborated with Grammy-winning guitarist Mark Lettieri on his latest album, *Feathered Creatures*.

Timeless thillanas

A collector’s volume of rare compositions, with detailed notations by Thanjavur S. Kalyanaraman, was released recently

P. Srihari

What do ragas Darbari Kanada, Sindhubhairavi, Brindavani, Dwijavanti, Kapi, Pahadi and Gavati have in common? Not only are they Hindustani ragas, but they were also chosen by Thanjavur S. Kalyanaraman for composing thillanas, which reveal his (SKR) musical acumen.

On the occasion of his 96th birth anniversary, celebrated recently at Arkay Convention Centre, Bhushany Kalyanaraman, disciple and wife of the late maestro, released *SKR Gems: Volume 1 - Thillanas* – a compilation of his seven thillanas with notation. A video album of the thillanas, rendered by Bhushany and her disciples Madhuvanthi Badri and Archanashree, was also premiered on YouTube on the occasion. Cleveland Sundaram, T.V. Gopalakrishnan, Nagai R. Muralidharan, V.V. Subrahmanyam and SKR’s nephew, Murali Iyer, reminisced about their association with the virtuoso vocalist.

Ever an explorer, SKR was not one to accept and be content with the

‘standard’. Expanding horizons was his second nature, and giving shape to ‘Dwi-madhyama panchama-varja mela ragas’ was a testament to this. It is pertinent to mention here that SKR abruptly dropped out of Presidency College, Madras, to pursue his musical dreams, as narrated by Murali Iyer. As it turned out, the music field gained, and the GNB legacy flourished. All through his life, he remained a seeker and an innovator who defied the convention.

SKR’s music struck a chord despite its structural complexity, said Sundaram. TVG recalled that the master was a hard worker, for whom nothing

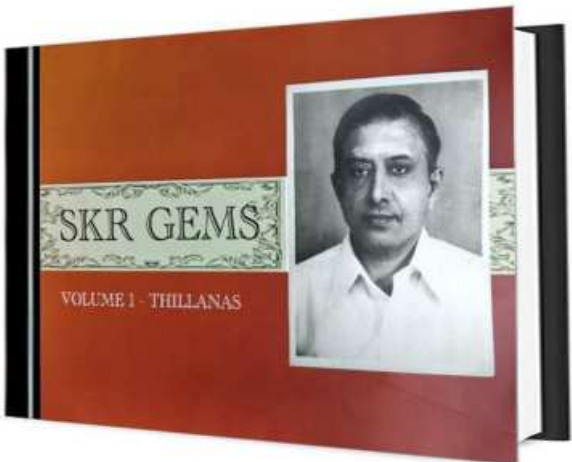


seemed impossible. His Kapi thillana calls for top laya control, noted Muralidharan.

SKR’s varnams, kritis and thillanas reflect a rare blend of rhythmic

sophistication, melodic beauty and aesthetic refinement, noted Sundaram in his foreword for the book. Six of the thillanas are in Tamil, with five of them on his favourite deity, Muruga. The lyrics are first given both in English and Tamil, and then with notation in both languages. With its neat layout and logical presentation, the book is a useful tool for music students aspiring to learn these thillanas. The first thillana in Darbari Kanada, given as a janya of the 21st mela Natabhairavi, should be read as a derivative of the 20th mela.

The rhythmic structure is as intricate as the thillanas warrant and is aesthetically pleasing as



Musical ode Thanjavur S. Kalyanaraman. (Below) Book cover. PHOTOS: THE HINDU ARCHIVES & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

well. The natural presence of ‘edhugai’ (second-letter alliteration) or ‘monai’ (first-letter alliteration) in the lyrics of all the compositions is a distinct value addition.

The reference ‘thaniyan’ (loner) to himself and the recollection of how Muruga redeemed him provide a poignant touch in the opening Darbari Kanada thillana set to Misra Chapu. The wordplay on ‘vel’ in the phrase ‘Endha velaikum kandha velaiei’ is enjoyable in the Sindhubhairavi song. Multiple edhugais mark the Brindavani thillana extolling Muruga. A pronounced ‘monai’ is the highlight of the Dwijavanti composition. The fifth one, in Kapi, is on Nataraja, set to Chatusra Jhampa, offering a complex rhythmic landscape. The Pahadi thillana brims with melodic appeal, while the final one, in Gavati, is composed in Sanskrit.

Bhushany later shared that a thillana in Bindumalini was a work in progress at the time of his demise, with only the charanam segment needing final touches.

The function was followed by a rendition of a few thillanas by Bhushany’s disciples and SKR’s grandnieces Aditi Iyer and Akshaya Iyer. Anuradha Sriram’s short concert of her guru SKR’s compositions – in which the last of the 36 dwi-madhyama ragas, ‘Chalasri’, provided a memorable finale to the event.

Scoring as a team

Anant Mysore and the accompanists presented nuanced essays



Good rapport Ananth Mysore with Srihari S. Raman (mridangam) and Sreeranjani Muthu Subramanian (violin). PHOTO: B. VELANKANNI RAJ

Renuka Suryanarayanan

A serene mood marked Ananth Mysore’s vocal recital, held recently as part of the HCL Concerts by The Music Academy at Kasturi Srinivasan Hall.

The U.S.-based vocalist’s training under eminent vidwans came through in his well-nuanced essays and deft handling of the kritis. Adding the requisite creative suites without excesses during the raga essays struck a chord with the listeners.

The highlight of his performance was Bhairavi raga, the main piece of the evening. Equally commendable were his accompanists – Sreeranjani Muthu Subramanian on the violin and Srihari S. Raman on the mridangam. The young team regaled with their dynamism.

The concert started with Tyagaraja’s Harikamboji raga kriti ‘Rama nannu brova ra’. The composer questions Rama: “Won’t you come to protect me? All that I have done is worship you, Sri Rama.” Ananth conveyed well the essence of this kriti. This was followed by a brief raga sketch, setting the tone for a poignant rendering of ‘Kamakshi

bangaru Kamakshi nannu brovave’ (Varali raga, Syama Sastri). Sreeranjani’s responses on the violin enriched this melodious raga outline.

Niraval by the artistes added colour to the line ‘Shukha shyamale shivashankar!’. Ananth chose to render Muthu Thandavar’s Tamil song ‘Kanaamal vinnile,’ in Nilambari raga. The composition is rendered in other ragas too.

Anant brought out the myriad facets of Bhairavi in his elaborate alapana. The violinist did justice to her version of the raga. The kriti was ‘Bala gopala palaya shumani’ (Muthuswami Dikshitar). The niraval-swara suite at ‘vainika gayaka guru guha nuta pura vairi vihita gopika manohara’ was well-crafted. While Ananth is honing his presentation skills, he would do well to work more on impact.

The mridangist’s rhythmic excellence came to the fore in the slow-paced Adi tala performed during the tani avartanam.

The concert concluded with ‘Sreenivasa thiruvengkata, (Hamsanandi raga, Papanasam Sivan) and a Kanada raga thillana.

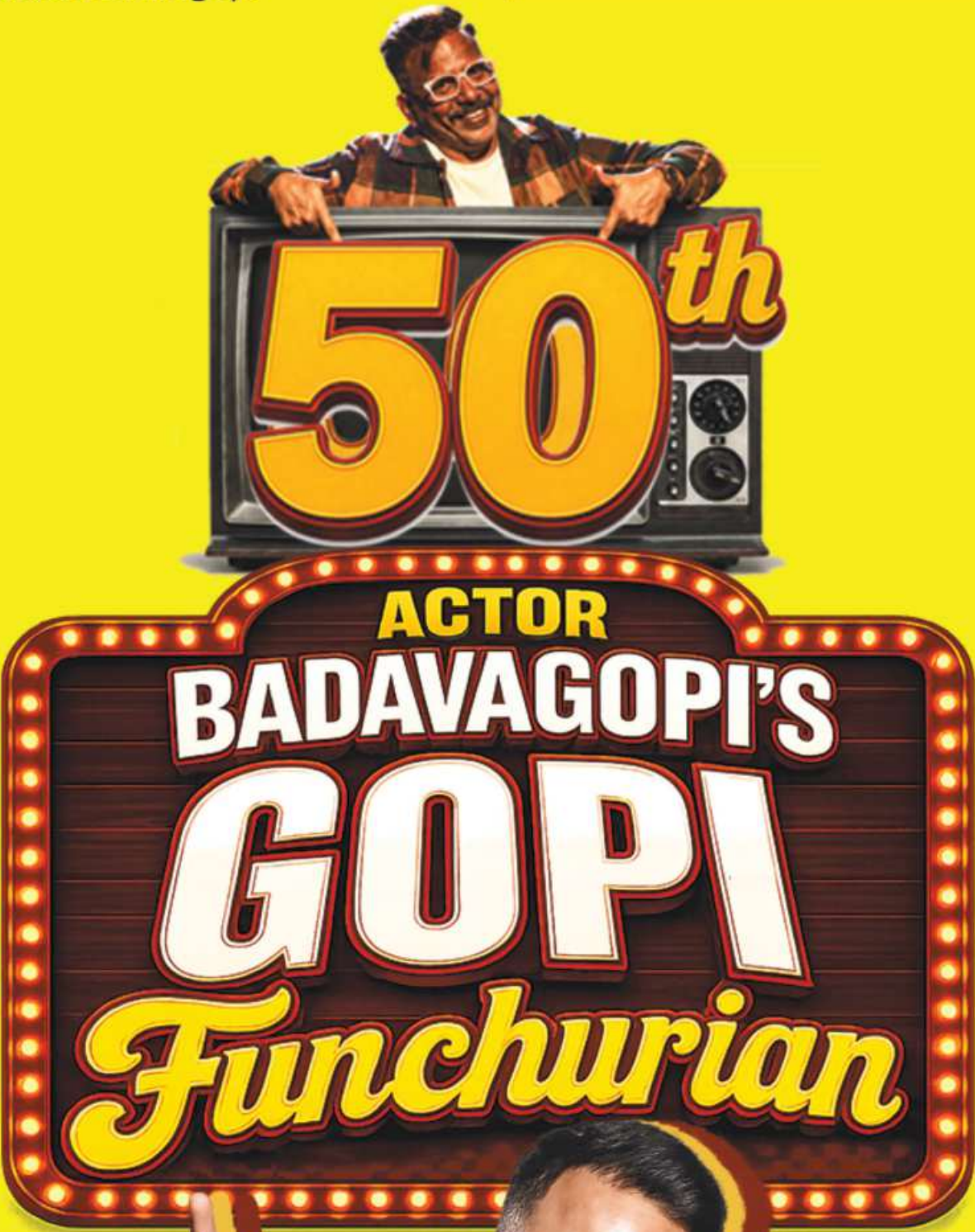
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Bank of rare songs

Gino Banks revives father Louiz's gems

Narendra Kusnur

Like his illustrious father Louiz Banks, drummer Gino Banks also thrives on reinvention. For a while, he has been thinking of revisiting his father's lesser-known compositions with younger musicians. This has taken shape as Gino Banks' Legacy project, which was recently presented in Studio Theatre at Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre in Mumbai.

The idea was to present an Indo-fusion set and Gino was accompanied by S. Akash on the bansuri, sarodist Pratik Srivastava, keyboardist Deivat Tapodhan, bassist Aditya Ahir and Ganesh Murali Iyer on Carnatic percussion and konnakol and vocalist Jyothishri Raghuram.

At the Mumbai concert, the set list included the Louiz Banks compositions — 'Raga of the heart', 'Benaras', 'Leap of faith' and '11 pieces of silver'. "Some of these have not been played live often." As a tribute to Ustad Zakir Hussain, they also presented the fusion-group Shakti's 'Bending the rules'.

Says Gino: "With a different line-up compared to what the compositions were originally written for, the basic melody was retained, and the musicians added their own flavour in the improvised solos.

The 43-year-old drummer reveals he plans to record the Legacy album. "My father will also play on a couple of tracks, and though the record will have the same musicians as the recent show, we will have some guests to add variety," says Gino, who first accompanied his father as a nine-year-old, playing percussion on some tracks with the fusion band — Sangam — during their Australia and China tours. Nine years later (in 2001), he played a full-set as a drummer for the first time with the group, Nexus, at Jazz By The Bay.

Right from his early days, he played alongside bassist Sheldon D'Silva. "We did our apprenticeship together with my father. As a drum and bass combo, we practised together and had similar influences." From his Nexus line-up, Gino has been collaborating with guitarist Chandresh Kudwa. "That's the rock side of my musical personality. Chandresh reconnected with me some years ago when he wanted to do the album *Free Spirit* with bassist Mohini Dey. We also did some shows together. This year, I performed on tour with Chandresh and his daughter, Eva, and it's been great."

Gino has also been curating the Mumbai Drum Day every year, besides organising a

monthly show at Prithvi Theatre in Juhu. He says, "Drum Day uses a mix of established artistes and young drummers who many people haven't heard. This year, we had a mix of drum set and taal."

Jazz@Prithvi was the idea of Kunal Kapoor, says Gino, who adds that Prithvi has been hosting the Udayaswar Indian classical music series, and this seemed like a good place for jazz too. He adds, "They have a no-mic policy, so it can be challenging for vocalists. But it helps them use their voice differently, and many musicians look forward to play there because it gives them a different experience."

While his focus is on jazz and fusion, Gino also has worked in Bollywood, having recorded drums for songs by Shreyas Puranik, Sachin-Jigar and Vishal-Shekhar, besides 'Ishq Mastana' from A.R. Rahman's new soundtrack *Main Vaapas Aaunga*.

One piece of advice he would like to give young Indian drummers is to familiarise themselves with Indian percussion styles. "The drum kit basically comes from the U.S. and has been used in jazz, rock and blues. But it always helps to learn Indian drumming techniques, as one can then interact better with other percussionists and also add an Indian touch to one's style," shares Gino.

But the biggest takeaway, says Gino, is performing with his father. He adds, "He's open-minded, encouraging others to do well, even if it means taking on a lesser role himself. For him, if everyone does well collectively, the music automatically succeeds." That's the legacy Gino is happy to carry forward.

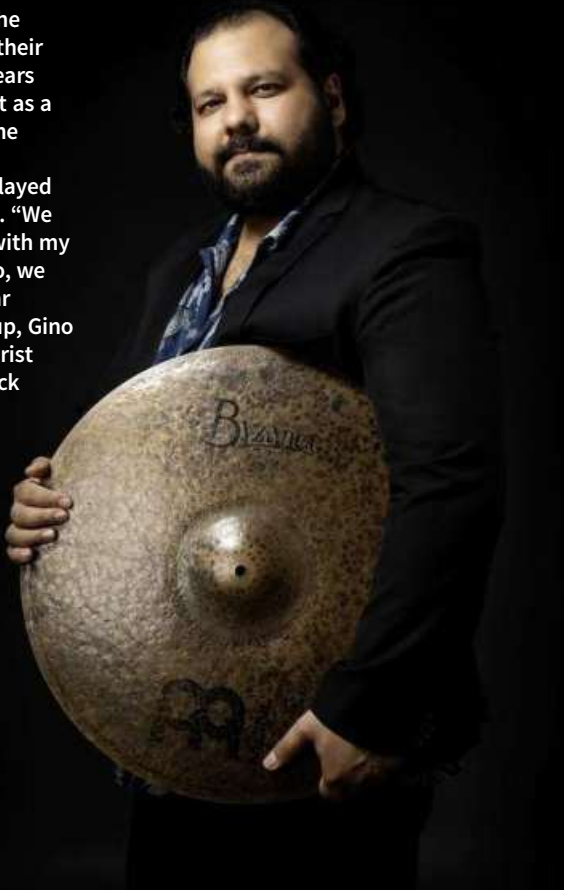


PHOTO: COURTESY: NATHAN SIGMAN



Field day Children, who went viral with their dance moves, will bring their energy to the FIFA World Cup Final; and (below) Shakira at the opening ceremony. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND AP

own the biggest stage in American television. Through 'Hips don't lie', 'She wolf', and that voice which trembles and refuses to behave, she never asked the world to meet her halfway. She assumed it would come along.

There is another side of her that rarely gets highlighted but explains the rest. Long before the Ghetto Kids, Shakira built the Pies Descalzos Foundation, named after one of her own albums, to fund schools and nutrition for children in the poorest corners of Colombia. Philanthropy, for her, has never been a press release. It is the same impulse as the music: a platform is only worth having if you can pull others onto it.

Her most recent chapter is also her most exposed. After a public separation and a few hard years, she returned with *Las Mujeres Ya No Lloran*, an album that turned heartbreak into something closer to resolve and won Best Latin Pop Album at the 2025 Grammys. The moments people remember from the tour that followed are rarely the pyrotechnics. They are the nights her sons, Milan and Sasha, walked out beside her in matching suits and sang their own small solos while she watched with undisguised pride. She folds her children into her work the way she folds in everything, openly and without apology.

That instinct is the real subject here. When she stands in that stadium this summer, the song will belong to the kids from Katwe finding their footing in front of a billion people, and to everyone watching them realise they were invited. That has always been the trick of her music: she makes the biggest possible stage feel like it has room for one more.

A different goal

Shakira makes space for Uganda's Ghetto Kids, who rose from the streets, on football's biggest stage

Rachel Rhine

A group of children from Kampala will stand at the centre of MetLife Stadium on July 19, and the woman beside them will look entirely at home. That image, equal parts improbable and inevitable, tells you almost everything about Shakira. When the 2026 World Cup final stages the first Super Bowl-style halftime show in the tournament's history, she will headline it, and she will not arrive alone. She has invited Uganda's Ghetto Kids to dance with her before the largest audience football can summon. The children have already appeared in the video for her song 'Dai Dai', the official anthem of the 2026 tournament.

No artiste is more bound to the sound of the World Cup than Shakira, and the bond was forged in a single summer. In 2010, 'Waka Waka (This Time for Africa)' became the actual pulse of a tournament, a chant that travelled from Johannesburg stadiums into living rooms where nobody spoke Spanish and everybody knew the words. It is still among the best-selling World Cup songs ever recorded. What gave it weight was the grace of the gesture. She built it on an African melody, performed it with the South African band Freshlyground, and handed the moment back to the place that lent it.

Consider the symmetry of what comes next. The Ghetto Kids were founded by Dauda Kavuma on the streets of Katwe, one of Kampala's poorest quarters, and they turned scarcity into something joyful and ungovernable. Over a decade they danced into a French Montana music video and onto the stages of Britain's Got Talent and America's Got Talent. Now Shakira is pulling them onto her stage. The woman who once gave Africa its World Cup anthem is handing a group of African children the spotlight, and the circle she opened in 2010 quietly closes. This is the throughline I keep returning to with her: she is forever enlarging the moment to make room for others in it.

To understand why that instinct feels so natural, it helps

to remember where she comes from. Born in Barranquilla in 1977 to a Colombian mother and a father of Lebanese descent, she turned that inheritance into the music itself. The hip movement, the whole world now imitates, began as an Arabic dance she learned as a child. The crossover that followed produced numbers that are difficult to overstate. She is the best-selling Latin female artiste of all time, the first Colombian to win a Grammy, and the holder of four Grammys and fifteen Latin Grammys. 'Laundry Service' made her a global name without asking her to abandon the strangeness that made her interesting, and in 2020 she stood beside Jennifer Lopez at the Super Bowl and reminded sixty thousand people that two Latina women could



CALENDAR

Book launch

C.P. Ramaswami Aiyar Institute of Indological Research releases the translations of three books by 18th century French travellers in India, Anquetil Duperron, Le Gentil and Pierre Sonnerat. The copies will be released by Prof. Raghuvendra Tanwar, chairman, Indian Council of Historical Research, and Hugues Boiteau, Scientific & Academic Attaché, Consulate General of France in Puducherry and Chennai. Presentations by the translators, Chitra Krishnan, Sumitra Muthukumar and Uma Damodar Sridhar will follow. The event will take place on June 20, 10 a.m. at The C.P. Ramaswami Aiyar Foundation, Alwarpet.



Solo recital

Natyarangam, the dance wing of Narada Gana Sabha, has organised the following Bharatanatyam performances at Swami Haridoss Giri mini hall on June 20. Amit Dole, disciple of Leela Samson (6 p.m.) followed by Sayujya Srinivasan's margam presentation at 7.30 p.m.

Digital release

Musician Rukmini Ramani's album *Karpaga Andhadhi - 27 Nakshatra Maalai*, comprising 27 devotional verses extolling goddess Karpagambal of Mylapore Kapaleeswarar temple, will be released on June 24, 6 p.m. at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Mylapore. K.N. Ramaswamy, director, BVB, will release the first copy of the album, which will be received by Dr. Sudha Seshayyan, former vice chancellor, Dr. MGR Medical University. The verses in the album are set in the Andhadhi format, where each begins with the concluding word of the previous verse. Lyrics, by Rukmini, are set to tune and rendered by S.J. Jananiy.



Garuda sevai

Srihari Dwadasha Garuda Seva Committee and Sridevi Bhoodevi Samedha Sri Thyaga Vinodha Perumal Temple, Mambakkam, have jointly organised the annual Garuda Sevai utsavam on June 21, from 7 a.m. to 6 p.m. On the occasion, processional deities from 12 temples in and around Ponmar will be seen on Garuda vahanam at Sri Thyaga Vinodha Perumal Temple. Details: Sri Thyaga Vinodha Perumal - Ponmar; Sri Thiruvengataperumal - Thiruvengatamangalam; Sri Venugopalan - Vijayanagar; Sri Varadaraja Perumal - Chithalapakkam; Narasimhar from Navanarasimhar temple - Thazhambur; Srinivasa Perumal - Kolapakkam; Sri Badri Narayanaswamy - Perungalathur; Sri Lakshminarayana Perumal - Karasangal; Sri Srinivasa Perumal - Pettai Street, Old Perungalathur; Sri Lakshmi Narayana Perumal - Urapakkam and Kanchivakkam; and Ramaswamy Perumal - Hastinapuram. The day-long utsavam will also include Veda parayanam, prabandham and namasankirtanam.

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